

Linux kernel 3.0 coming soon

Linus Torvalds, creator of Linux has declared that the next version of the Linux Kernel will be 3.0 – ending the 15-year long v2 cycle

New OSS compiler

PatScale's EKOPath 4 Compiler Suite, which used to cost nearly \$2,000 has been open-sourced

Five Linux distros for your ageing computer

Kshitij Sobti

kshitij.sobti@thinkdigit.com

The immense modularity of Linux makes it possible for one to run on hardware that has long been out of date. Often a computer even a few years old will be able to run the latest Linux distro without problems, and Linux is usually a breath of fresh life for such computers.

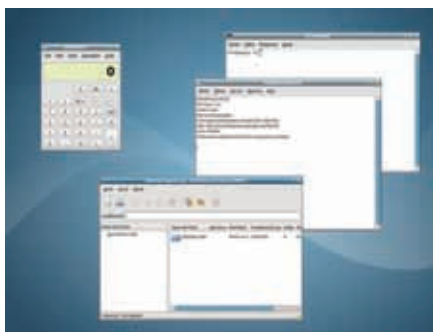
However there are computers lying in the more dusty corners of our garages, which these newer Linux distros will refuse to run on.

While it is possible to run an older Linux version or even an older Windows version, often the best approach is to opt for a distribution designed specifically with older computers in mind. While there may be other distros that are just light enough to work on older machines, we take a look at five of them.

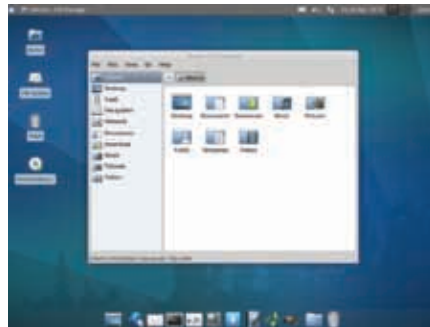
Xubuntu and Lubuntu

Xubuntu is an official Ubuntu version that uses the XFCE desktop environment instead of the Gnome / Unity used by Ubuntu. Xubuntu is significantly lighter, requiring a quarter of the resources of its counterpart Ubuntu. While Ubuntu requires at least 1 GB of RAM, XFCE can make do with just 256 MB.

Xubuntu replaces LibreOffice used in the latest version of Ubuntu with Abiword



Productivity suites won't hamper your work



Xubuntu is the lighter variant of Ubuntu

(a word processor), and Gnumeric (a spreadsheet application). These application do not have as many features, but are compatible with the same file formats, and are considerably lighter.

Since the OS is Ubuntu-based, it will run any Ubuntu application. Although it is important to note that the applications you run might demand greater resources.

Xubuntu includes Firefox, however you will be better off installing a lighter browser such as Midori which has lower memory requirements.

Lubuntu, like Xubuntu is an (now official) derivative of Ubuntu which uses the LXDE desktop environment. It has even lower system requirements, yielding a usable system at just 128 MB RAM.

CrunchBang

CrunchBang or #! is a Debian-based Linux OS that emphasises simplicity and speed. It uses a very minimalistic window manager called Openbox — there is an Xfce version available as well — that is even lighter than Xfce. The interface is bare, having only the essentials, a desktop switcher cum taskbar,

and no applications menu. This makes a great choice for netbooks as well.

Despite the light interface it has an impressive number of applications. Thanks to the included VLC player one can play nearly any media format, including DVDs. Flash and MP3 support are also included by default so you can use it for playing media in proprietary formats out of the box. It even includes the powerful GIMP image editor out of the box. CrunchBang uses the open-source version of Chrome, the Chromium browser. Like Xubuntu, it uses AbiWord and Gnumeric instead of LibreOffice.

CrunchBang also has very low system requirements. Technically it is possible to install on a system with



CrunchBang 10 has a minimalist interface

as little as 64 MB of RAM, but such a system would not be very usable.

Zenwalk Linux

Zenwalk tries to cater to a wide range of users, and hence offers multiple versions, all of which are lightweight. The five versions are: Standard, Core, Live, Gnome and Openbox. The Standard one uses the XFCE desktop environment; Core comes with only a command line interface, which the user can then build on; the Live version is similar to the standard version but designed to run off a CD. The Gnome and Openbox editions use the Gnome desktop environment and